Helm Marine Platform

Go-To-Market & Disruption Marketing Strategy

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Executive Summary

Helm enters the New Zealand marine and fishing market as a **challenger brand** with a structural advantage that its incumbents cannot easily replicate: a technology-first platform that knows the customer's boat, learns from every interaction, and builds a genuine community around shared passion. Burnsco has 23,607 Facebook followers and 5,214 Instagram followers after decades in business. Marine Deals positions itself as a price-led supermarket. Neither has a meaningful content strategy, a community programme, or any AI-powered personalisation.

The opportunity is not to compete with them on their terms — it is to make their terms irrelevant.

This strategy is built on a single governing insight: **in a passionate niche market, community is the moat**. The boaties and fishos of New Zealand are not looking for the cheapest widget; they are looking for a brand that understands them, respects their expertise, and makes their time on the water better. Helm will be that brand.

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1. Market Intelligence: The Landscape We Are Entering

The Audience

New Zealand has one of the highest rates of boat ownership per capita in the world, with approximately 595,000 active marine fishers and an estimated fleet of over 200,000 registered recreational vessels. A 2018 Fisheries Research study found that NZ resident marine fishers spend an average of $998 per person per year on equipment and accessories — a total addressable accessories market of approximately$ 300–400 million NZD in 2026 terms.

This audience is concentrated in the North Island, with the Hauraki Gulf, Bay of Islands, Coromandel, and Northland being the most active boating regions. It skews male (approximately 75%), aged 30–65, and is digitally active — particularly on Facebook and YouTube.

The Competitor Weakness

Competitor	Social Following	Content Strategy	Community Programme	AI/Personalisation
Burnsco	FB: 23,607 / IG: 5,214	Product promotions, occasional competitions	None	None
Marine Deals	IG: 8,000	Price-led promotions	None	None
Smart Marine	Minimal	Minimal	None	None
Helm (Target)	FB: 50K / IG: 25K / TikTok: 10K by Month 12	Community-first, expert content, UGC	Crew Rewards + Crew Teams	AI First Mate, My Vessel

Burnsco's Facebook page generates approximately 136 people "talking about this" per week — a 0.58% engagement rate. This is the floor, not the ceiling. A well-executed community strategy should achieve 3–5% engagement rates within the first year.

The Media Ecosystem

The NZ marine media landscape is fragmented but engaged. The key channels for reaching our audience are:

Print & Digital Media

- **Boating New Zealand** — Monthly magazine, the authoritative voice of the NZ boating community. 132 pages, monthly. Partnership and advertising opportunities.
- **NZ Fishing News** — Quarterly magazine, focused on recreational fishing. Strong readership in the game fishing and offshore communities.
- **Fishing.net.nz** — The largest NZ fishing website, hosting the tournament calendar and community forums.

YouTube Influencers (Key Partners)

Channel	Subscribers	Niche	Tier
Ultimate Fishing (Matt Watson)	244,000	Offshore, game fishing, trailer boats	Macro
The Lateral Line	76,800	Inshore, kingfish, snapper, adventure	Mid-tier
Trout Hunting NZ (Gareth)	103,000	Fly fishing, freshwater	Macro
Fishing & Adventure TV	48,500	General NZ fishing, TV show	Mid-tier
JE Wilds	163,000	Adventure fishing, offshore	Macro
Crazy About Fly Fishing	50,000	Fly fishing, saltwater	Mid-tier
REEL KIWI FISHING	10,700	Hauraki Gulf, softbaiting, jigging	Micro
Shimano Fishing NZ	7,900	Brand-affiliated, product reviews	Nano

TikTok

- **extremefishingnz** — 96,200 followers, 2.6M likes. Korean-Kiwi team, Daiwa NZ. Offshore boat fishing. High-engagement, viral content.
- **kodybronzfishing** — Growing NZ fishing TikTok presence.

Facebook Communities (Organic Seeding Targets)

- NZ Fishing Community — Large, active group
- NZ BIG GAME FISHING - Catch & Release — Game fishing specialists
- New Zealand Lure Fishing — Softbait and lure community
- NZ Boating Community — General boating
- The NZ Fishing World Forum — Discussion and debate

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2. The Disruption Philosophy: Community Before Commerce

The most powerful challenger brand marketing playbook of the last decade — from RevZilla (motorcycles) to YETI (outdoor) to Patagonia (outdoor apparel) — follows the same pattern: **build a community of true believers before you ask for the sale**. RevZilla's "Common Tread" editorial platform, launched alongside their e-commerce store, became so trusted that it was the primary reason customers visited the site even when they were not buying. YETI built a $1.7 billion brand almost entirely on community and content, not advertising.

The governing principle for Helm is: **every piece of marketing must provide genuine value to the audience, not just promote a product**. A guide on how to set up a softbait rig for Hauraki Gulf snapper is marketing. A post saying "20% off softbait this weekend" is noise.

This philosophy shapes every element of the strategy below.

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3. Pre-Launch Strategy: Building the Waitlist (Months -6 to 0)

The six months before launch are the most critical. The goal is to arrive on launch day with a warm, engaged audience ready to convert — not to launch cold into an empty room.

3.1 The "First Mate" Waitlist Campaign

A dedicated landing page will be built six months before launch. The page will not describe the platform in detail; instead, it will ask a single, compelling question: *"What if your boat had its own AI crew member?"* The call to action is simple: enter your email to be first on board.

The waitlist will be gamified using a referral mechanic (modelled on the Robinhood and Superhuman launches): every person who joins gets a unique referral link. Referring friends moves you up the queue, and the top referrers receive exclusive "Captain" tier founding membership, permanent double points, and a personalised Helm merchandise pack. This turns every waitlist member into a recruiter.

Target: 10,000 waitlist sign-ups before launch day.

3.2 The “Ultimate NZ Fishing Rig” Pre-Launch Competition

This is the single most important pre-launch initiative. We will partner with three or four major brands — ideally a NZ boat builder (Stabicraft or Rayglass), an engine manufacturer (Yamaha Marine NZ), and an electronics brand (Garmin or Simrad) — to offer the most significant prize in NZ fishing history: a fully-rigged fishing boat valued at 250,000–350,000 NZD.

Entry is free and requires only a waitlist sign-up. The competition will run for the entire six-month pre-launch period, with weekly “bonus entry” opportunities (e.g., follow us on Instagram, share a post, tag a fishing mate). The prize will be announced and promoted at the Auckland Boat Show in March 2026, giving it a natural media moment.

The mechanics of this competition serve multiple strategic purposes simultaneously: it builds the waitlist, generates massive media coverage (a $300,000 giveaway is genuinely newsworthy), creates social sharing momentum, and establishes Helm as a brand that is serious about the community from day one. The cost of the prize, when shared across three or four brand partners, is manageable for each individual partner while the combined value is extraordinary.

3.3 The Founding Ambassador Programme

We will identify and personally recruit 20 founding ambassadors from across the NZ fishing and boating community. These will not necessarily be the biggest influencers — they will be the most respected, most authentic voices. A mix of profiles is essential:

Ambassador Type	Example Profile	Why
The Game Fishing Legend	An established Northland or Coromandel tournament angler with a loyal local following	Credibility in the highest-value segment
The Hauraki Gulf Regular	A snapper and kingfish obsessive with a strong Instagram presence	Reaches the largest single audience of NZ boaties
The Softbait Specialist	A mid-tier YouTube creator focused on softbaiting technique	Reaches the fastest-growing fishing technique segment
The Family Boatie	A parent who documents family boating adventures	Reaches the aspirational, lifestyle-oriented audience
The Trailerboat Tinkerer	A DIY boatie who documents maintenance and upgrades	Directly aligned with the “My Vessel” garage feature
The Game Fishing Skipper	A charter boat skipper who runs game fishing trips	Credibility with the high-spend, high-engagement game fishing community
The South Island Adventurer	A Marlborough Sounds or Fiordland boating adventurer	Geographic diversity; reaches the South Island audience
The Female Angler	A prominent female fishing voice in NZ	Reaches an underserved but growing audience segment

Each founding ambassador will receive: a monthly retainer (500–1,500 NZD depending on their reach), a full Helm merchandise kit, early platform access, and a dedicated “Founding Ambassador” badge on their profile.

Their only contractual obligation is to create a minimum of two authentic pieces of content per month about their experience with the platform. We will never script their content.

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4. Launch Strategy (Months 1–3)

4.1 The Staged Rollout

Access to the platform will be granted in batches of 1,000 users per day, in waitlist order. This is not just a server management strategy — it is a marketing strategy. Scarcity creates desire. People who are still waiting will be more motivated to engage with the platform when they finally get access, and the daily "batch" announcements give us a reason to post on social media every single day for the first month.

4.2 The "My Vessel" Onboarding Competition

The single most important action a new user can take is to register their vessel in the "My Vessel" garage. This is the foundation of everything — the AI personalisation, the compatible parts filtering, the service reminders. We will incentivise this with a major launch competition.

The "Know Your Boat" Competition: The user who creates the most complete and accurate vessel profile in the first 30 days wins a $10,000 electronics upgrade (a Garmin or Simrad chartplotter/sounder package). Completeness is scored algorithmically: HIN entered, engine details verified, all OEM equipment fields populated, and a photo of the vessel uploaded. This competition directly serves the business goal of populating the boat OEM database with real-world, user-verified data.

4.3 The "First Crew" Challenge

The first 100 Crews (teams) to reach the maximum points multiplier tier within the first 60 days of launch will receive a permanent "First Crew" badge on their profile and a $500 Helm store credit for the entire team to share. This drives the formation of teams and collective spending behaviour from day one.

4.4 The Hutchwilco NZ Boat Show (May 2026)

The Hutchwilco NZ Boat Show at Auckland Showgrounds (14–17 May 2026) is the single most important event in the NZ marine calendar, attracting tens of thousands of visitors over four days. This is our official public launch moment.

The Helm Stand will not look like a retail stand. It will be an interactive experience:

- **The First Mate Demo Zone:** A row of iPads where visitors can interact with the AI First Mate. They enter their boat details and ask it a question. The quality and intelligence of the response is the product demo.
- **The "My Vessel" Leaderboard:** A large screen showing the top-ranked vessel profiles from our launch competition, with the leader's boat photo and details displayed.
- **The Ambassador Lounge:** A comfortable seating area where our Founding Ambassadors will be present throughout the show, available for meet-and-greets and conversations.
- **The Helm Dash Demo:** A live demonstration of the Helm Dash delivery concept, with a Helm Dash vessel visible in the harbour and a real-time delivery of a product ordered from the stand.

- **The Grand Prize Draw:** The winner of the “Ultimate NZ Fishing Rig” pre-launch competition will be drawn live on the Helm stand on the first day of the show, in front of a crowd. This will be filmed and will generate significant social media content.

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5. Scale & Dominance Strategy (Months 4–12)

5.1 Events Calendar: Owning the NZ Marine Moment

The NZ marine events calendar is rich and predictable. We will build our marketing calendar around these events, ensuring Helm has a presence — either as a sponsor, an exhibitor, or a content partner — at every major moment in the marine year.

Month	Event	Helm Activation
March 2026	Auckland Boat Show (5–8 March)	Pre-launch competition draw; platform demo stand
March 2026	Kubota Billfish Classic, Whitianga (11–14 March)	Tournament sponsor; Helm Dash on-water delivery service; ambassador content
May 2026	Hutchwilco NZ Boat Show (14–17 May)	**Official launch event**; headline stand; ambassador lounge; Grand Prize draw
June–Aug 2026	Winter Tuna Tournament season	Social media content series; Helm Dash Hauraki Gulf activation
Nov–Jan 2026/27	Game fishing season (Northland, Coromandel)	Ambassador content; game fishing agent launch; tournament sponsorship
Jan 2027	Hunting & Fishing Marlin & Tuna Tournament, Gisborne	Sponsor; Helm Dash trial in Gisborne
Feb 2027	Eldorado Billfish Tournament	Sponsor; ambassador content
March 2027	Kubota Billfish Classic (Title Sponsor target)	Full title sponsorship; Helm Dash as official on-water parts service

5.2 The Kubota Billfish Classic: The Crown Jewel

The Kubota Billfish Classic in Whitianga is the world’s largest billfish tournament, attracting 470+ boats in 2025 with a waiting list. Each boat carries four to five people, meaning the event directly engages 2,000–2,500 of the most passionate, highest-spending game fishers in the country. The event has massive media coverage in Boating NZ, NZ Fishing News, Marlin Magazine (international), and social media.

Our strategy is to become the title sponsor of this event for the 2027 season. In 2026, we will be a presenting sponsor, using the event to launch the “Game Fishing Expert” AI agent and to run the first live Helm Dash on-water delivery service. In 2027, as title sponsor, the event becomes “The Helm Billfish Classic” — and every piece of coverage carries our brand.

5.3 The “Helm Dash” Hauraki Gulf Summer Campaign

The Hauraki Gulf is the most densely boated waterway in New Zealand, with hundreds of vessels at anchor on any given summer weekend. Our Helm Dash flagship vessel will operate in this area from October through March.

The summer campaign will be built around a simple, memorable proposition: **“Forgot something? We’ll bring it to you.”** We will run paid social media advertising targeting people in the Hauraki Gulf region during summer weekends, showing a Helm Dash vessel delivering a cold drink and a fishing lure to a boat at anchor. The creative will be humorous and aspirational. The first delivery in each new area will be free, creating a powerful word-of-mouth moment.

We will partner with popular Hauraki Gulf destinations — Waiheke Island, Great Barrier Island, Kawau Island — to place Helm Dash collection points at local marinas and wharves, expanding the service beyond direct-to-vessel delivery.

5.4 Social Media: The Content Engine

Our social media strategy is built on a content calendar that is 80% value-driven and 20% promotional. The ratio is non-negotiable.

Instagram & Facebook (Daily)

The daily content calendar follows a weekly rhythm:

Day	Content Theme	Example
Monday	“Maintenance Monday”	60-second video: “How to check your impeller before the season”
Tuesday	“Tackle Tuesday”	Product spotlight with genuine expert commentary from an ambassador
Wednesday	“Waypoint Wednesday”	Stunning image of a NZ boating location, user-submitted
Thursday	“Throwback Thursday”	Historical NZ fishing/boating imagery or a classic catch story
Friday	“Forecast Friday”	Weekend weather and fishing conditions for key NZ regions
Saturday	“On the Water”	Real-time UGC from our community — best photo of the day wins
Sunday	“The Debrief”	Community round-up: best catches, best stories, best tips from the week

TikTok (3x per week)

TikTok requires a fundamentally different approach: fast, educational, and entertaining. Our TikTok strategy will focus on three content formats:

- **“Did You Know?”** — 30-second quick tips that make experienced boaties feel smart and new boaties feel empowered. Examples: “The one knot that every NZ fisho needs to know,” “Why your bilge pump is probably installed wrong.”
- **“First Mate Answers”** — Screen recordings of the AI First Mate answering genuinely interesting questions, with a voiceover. This is product marketing that does not feel like product marketing.
- **“Helm Dash Deliveries”** — Short, cinematic clips of Helm Dash deliveries on the Hauraki Gulf. A boat at anchor, a Helm Dash vessel approaching, a happy customer receiving their order. These will be the most

shareable content we produce.

YouTube (Weekly)

YouTube is our long-form authority channel. We will publish one long-form video per week, alternating between:

- **Ambassador Episodes:** Full-length fishing and boating adventures from our ambassador network, co-produced with Helm branding.
- **Expert Guides:** In-depth tutorials on topics like "How to set up your boat's 12V electrical system" or "The complete guide to game fishing in the Coromandel."
- **Event Coverage:** Full-length coverage of tournaments and events we sponsor.

5.5 The "#HelmAdventures" UGC Competition

Every month, we will run a photo and video competition on Instagram and Facebook under the hashtag `#HelmAdventures`. The prize will rotate monthly — one month it might be a $1,000 tackle pack, the next it might be a Crew Rewards experience (a private fishing masterclass with a renowned NZ skipper).

The mechanics are simple: post a photo or video of your best boating or fishing moment, tag `@helmmarine` and use `#HelmAdventures`, and follow our account. The winner is chosen by our team and announced every first Monday of the month.

This competition serves three strategic purposes: it generates a constant stream of authentic, high-quality UGC; it grows our follower base through the tag-and-follow mechanic; and it reinforces the brand association between Helm and the best moments on the water.

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6. Competition Strategy: The Full Programme

Competitions are not just a marketing tactic for Helm — they are a core part of the product experience, integrated with the Crew Rewards programme and the "My Vessel" garage. Every competition is designed to serve a business goal beyond brand awareness.

Competition	Timing	Prize Value	Business Goal	Entry Mechanic
“Ultimate NZ Fishing Rig”	Pre-launch (6 months)	250,000–350,000	Waitlist growth	Email sign-up + referral
“Know Your Boat”	Launch month	$10,000	Vessel profile completion	Most complete vessel profile
“First Crew” Challenge	Launch months 1–2	$500 store credit per team	Crew formation	First 100 teams to reach max multiplier
”#HelmAdventures”	Monthly (ongoing)	500–1,000	UGC generation	Photo/video + hashtag
“Helm Dash First Delivery”	Summer season	Free delivery	Helm Dash adoption	First delivery in each new region is free
“Best Catch of the Season”	End of game fishing season	$5,000 experience prize	Engagement, brand association	Photo submission via platform
“Crew of the Year”	Annual	$20,000 group experience	Crew loyalty, team spending	Highest collective Crew spend for the year
“Young Skipper”	Annual	$2,500 safety gear pack	Brand values, next generation	Under-18 fishing photo competition

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7. The Crew Rewards Experience Catalogue: Marketing Through Aspiration

The Crew Rewards programme’s experience catalogue is itself a powerful marketing tool. When people see the experiences available — a private game fishing charter to the Three Kings Islands, a weekend at a remote South Island fishing lodge, a masterclass with a legendary NZ fishing guide — they do not just want to earn points; they want to tell their friends about it.

The initial experience catalogue will include:

- **“The Three Kings Expedition”** — A private 5-day game fishing charter to the Three Kings Islands aboard a luxury vessel, for a Crew of up to 6. The most aspirational prize in the catalogue.
- **“The Marlborough Sounds Cruise”** — A 3-day bareboat charter in the Marlborough Sounds, fully provisioned, for a Crew of up to 8.
- **“The Taupo Trout Masterclass”** — A private 2-day guided fly fishing experience on the Tongariro River with a renowned guide, including accommodation at a riverside lodge.
- **“The Hauraki Gulf Sunset Cruise”** — A private evening charter on the Hauraki Gulf for a Crew of up to 10, with catering and a Helm merchandise pack.
- **“The Game Fishing Masterclass”** — A full-day private session with one of NZ’s most respected game fishing skippers, including rigging, tackle selection, and on-water coaching.

These experiences will be photographed and filmed professionally and used as aspirational content across all social media channels. The message is simple: **spend with Helm, earn experiences money cannot buy**.

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8. Media & PR Strategy

8.1 Trade Media

We will build relationships with the editors of Boating New Zealand and NZ Fishing News from the pre-launch phase. Our story — an AI-powered marine platform with on-demand water delivery — is genuinely newsworthy. We will offer exclusive first-look interviews and features to both publications in exchange for cover stories at launch.

8.2 Mainstream Media

The “Ultimate NZ Fishing Rig” competition and the Helm Dash concept are both strong mainstream media stories. We will pitch to:

- **Newshub / TVNZ** — The Helm Dash story (“Uber for the Hauraki Gulf”) is a natural fit for a summer lifestyle segment.
- **NZ Herald / Stuff** — The AI First Mate concept is a technology story as much as a fishing story.
- **Radio Hauraki / The Rock** — Both stations have strong boating and fishing audiences and have run boat giveaway competitions in the past.

8.3 Podcast Sponsorship

The NZ fishing and boating podcast landscape is small but growing. We will sponsor the most relevant podcasts, including any produced by our ambassador network, with a consistent message and a trackable promo code.

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9. Budget Allocation Framework (Year 1)

The following is a high-level budget framework for the first 12 months. Actual figures will depend on the total marketing budget allocated.

Category	Allocation (% of budget)	Rationale
Competitions & Prizes	30%	The “Ultimate NZ Fishing Rig” prize is the single biggest investment; it generates the most value.
Events & Sponsorships	25%	Hutchwilco Boat Show stand, Auckland Boat Show, Kubota Billfish Classic presenting sponsorship.
Influencer & Ambassador Programme	20%	20 ambassadors at 500–1,500/month retainer + content production support.
Content Production	10%	Professional photography, videography, and editing for YouTube and social media.
Paid Social Media	10%	Targeted Facebook/Instagram/TikTok advertising, primarily for the pre-launch waitlist campaign and Helm Dash summer activation.
PR & Media	5%	Press release distribution, media relationship management, podcast sponsorships.

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10. The Disruption Flywheel: How It All Connects

The individual tactics above are powerful in isolation. Together, they form a self-reinforcing flywheel that compounds over time.

Step 1 — Build the Community: The pre-launch waitlist campaign and Founding Ambassador Programme create a warm, engaged audience before we spend a dollar on the platform.

Step 2 — Launch with Genuine Value: The AI First Mate, My Vessel garage, and Crew Rewards programme provide real, daily value that no competitor can match. This converts waitlist members into loyal customers.

Step 3 — Incentivise the Right Behaviours: Competitions are designed to drive specific platform behaviours (vessel registration, Crew formation) that generate valuable data and network effects.

Step 4 — Turn Customers into Content Creators: The `#HelmAdventures` UGC programme and the Ambassador network turn our most passionate customers into a distributed content engine, dramatically reducing our cost per impression.

Step 5 — Own the Events: As we grow, we invest our brand equity into owning the most prestigious events in the NZ marine calendar. This creates a halo effect that reaches audiences who are not yet customers.

Step 6 — The Flywheel Accelerates: Each new customer who joins a Crew brings their friends. Each Crew that earns an experience tells the story. Each ambassador video reaches new audiences. Each event sponsorship brings new users to the top of the funnel. The flywheel accelerates with every rotation.

This is how a challenger brand, with a fraction of the marketing budget of an incumbent, builds a dominant market position. Not by out-spending, but by out-caring.

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11. Key Performance Indicators (12-Month Targets)

Metric	3-Month Target	6-Month Target	12-Month Target
Waitlist sign-ups	10,000	—	—
Registered users	2,000	8,000	20,000
Completed vessel profiles	1,500	5,000	12,000
Active Crews	200	800	2,500
Instagram followers	5,000	12,000	25,000
Facebook followers	8,000	20,000	50,000
TikTok followers	1,000	3,000	10,000
YouTube subscribers	500	2,000	8,000
Monthly website sessions	20,000	60,000	150,000
Helm Dash deliveries	100	500	2,000
Monthly revenue (NZD)	$50,000	$200,000	$600,000

This document is a living strategy. It should be reviewed and updated quarterly as market conditions evolve and performance data informs our understanding of what is working.